2010s rather than the 2020s, because we have gained a modicum of historical perspective on events of the 2010s.

Part 2 argues that we are creating an entirely new kind of information network without pausing to reckon with its implications. It emphasises the shift from organic to inorganic information networks. The Roman Empire, the Catholic Church and the USSR all relied on carbon-based brains to process information and make decisions. The silicon-based computers that dominate the new information network function in radically different ways. For better or worse, silicon chips are free from many of the limitations that organic biochemistry imposes on carbon neurons. Silicon chips can create spies that never sleep, financiers that never forget and despots that never die. How will this change society, economics and politics?

The third and final part of the book – 'Computer Politics' – examines how different kinds of societies might deal with the threats and promises of the inorganic information network. Will carbon-based life-forms like us have a chance of understanding and controlling the new information network? As noted above, history isn't deterministic, and for at least a few more years we Sapiens still have the power to shape our future.

Accordingly, chapter 9 explores how democracies might deal with the inorganic network. How, for example, can flesh-and-blood politicians make financial decisions if the financial system is increasingly controlled by AI and the very meaning of money comes to depend on inscrutable algorithms? How can democracies maintain a public conversation about anything – be it finance or gender – if we can no longer know whether we are talking with another human or with a chatbot masquerading as a human?

Chapter 10 explores the potential impact of the inorganic network on totalitarianism. While dictators would be happy to get rid of all public conversations, they have their own fears of AI. Autocracies are based on terrorising and censoring their own agents. But how can a human dictator terrorise an AI, censor its unfathomable processes or prevent it from seizing power for itself?

Finally, chapter 11 explores how the new information network could influence the balance of power between democratic and totalitarian societies on the global level. Will AI tilt the balance decisively in favor of one camp? Will the world split into hostile blocs whose rivalry makes all of us easy prey for an out-of-control AI? Or can we unite in defence of our common interests?